

To those who stop and smell the roses,

I often quote this funny maxim: “Writing about music is like dancing about architecture.” To generalize the saying: “Talking about art is like dancing about architecture.”

How true is this? Well, music is by definition infinite. The sound waves that we hear vibrate across an interminable order of overtones, creating timbres unimaginably nuanced and unique. To perfectly describe these sounds; to even attempt to describe their emotional resonance, is futile. Yet, to speak of these sounds as inaccessible; to treat the theater, opera, ballet, orchestra, band, choir as overly complicated in its fathomless essence, is a disservice to the immediate power of these forms. I find it highly prudent to articulate this power in a way that is educational, accessible, and inspiring.

Musicologist Vladimir Jankélévitch illuminates this point eloquently:

“...the musical mystery is not ‘what cannot be spoken of,’ the untellable, but the ineffable. Death, the black night, is untellable because it is impenetrable shadow and despairing nonbeing, and because a wall that cannot be breached bars us from its mystery: unable to be spoken of, then, because there is absolutely nothing to say, rendering us mute, overwhelming reason, transfixing human discourse on the point of its Medusa stare. And the ineffable, in complete contrast, cannot be explained because there are infinite and interminable things to be said of it: such is the mystery of God, whose depths cannot be sounded, the inexhaustible mystery of love, both Eros and Caritas, the poetic mystery par excellence.

When I started high school, I wanted to be a concert pianist. I loved the idea of bringing people into my world and showing them the wonder and magic between notes on the page. The masters of the keyboard don’t just play exceptionally well. The piano becomes a vessel through which the composer and the performer speak their truths; through which their voices resonate on mysterious frequencies and vibrate the soul. Perhaps it was important, even necessary, to serve as a special conduit of ephemeral yet ineffable and beautiful sincerity: a kind of authenticity and emotional complexity I felt was lacking in the world.

During university, I began conducting orchestras and directing theater. I realized that such truths can be found while elevating others to discover their own. The instrument no longer serves as the primary vessel. The entire production and creative process became the incubator for humility and intellectual dynamism. I quickly fell in love with the idea of creating systems and institutions that foster such ideals.

Hence, music and art demonstrate a highly important yet fragile societal pillar: social cohesion. Much of this cohesion comes through the flux between the Self and the Other: the varying tension, intensification, reconciliation, and assimilation of one’s own identity against everyone else’s. This relationship manifests in different contexts: artist-audience, artist-artist, teacher-student, child-parent, friend-stranger. These spontaneous interactions are the

foundation of art's ability to stir the heart and mind. Even in solitude, one's relationship with an artwork illuminates deep thoughts because it implicates the feelings and ideas of a craftsman, a zeitgeist, and a reality that is not one's own. It is through a confrontation of the Other that one can discover what parts of the identity have value.

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There is another funny maxim that goes like this: “There are three things we can't avoid: Death, taxes, and AGI.”

When Artificial General Intelligence takes hold of society, I worry about the implications on art. On the one hand, technology will democratize and amplify people's voices easier than ever before. Self-expression will proliferate. These conditions usher a new large wave of creativity, given storytelling is a large focus of creativity. However, this system does not only promote art to *share*, but also art to *consume* at an unprecedented scale. AGI will create the movie I want to watch, the music I want to listen to, and the content I want to see on my feed.

With the impending infinitude of AI art, I predict society will tolerate eclecticism less and less because everyone will consume exactly what they want. Without the tension part of the four-axis model of social cohesion, people will forget what true intellectual discomfort feels like. If people cannot tolerate aesthetic differences, how will they tolerate each other?

It's not that the demand for live experiences will go down. It's that our most visceral, most basic capacity for difference and discomfort will become physiologically intolerable. The grammar and vocabulary of *art* will become too foreign and that of *entertainment* will be all that is acceptable. The live experience economy will certainly persist. My generation and those above me crave for in-person connection. But for my children and my children's children, will they truly fight en masse for the same level of engagement? While I want to think optimistically that the desire for in-person connection will only heighten, I worry for the industry's capacity to keep up with technology's ever-mutating grasp on humanity.

We need art now more than ever. Not commercial art, but art for art's sake. One of art's other functions, which is related to social cohesion, is to help societies interpret experiences—historical events, collective trauma, identity, or change. It can shape cultural memory and provide frameworks through which people understand themselves and others.

Arts patronage is perhaps one of the most misunderstood and underutilized systems today. It allowed for people like Aristotle, Da Vinci, and Beethoven to compose their magnum opuses. Today, almost all financial capital in the arts fuel the entertainment industrial complex or the preservation of “museum pieces.” The little capital that is directly funding the creation of new vibrant art is fostering the creation of things that are not necessarily beautiful.

Most things that are profoundly beautiful are wrapped up in the canon of the past and in the splendor of the natural world. Why can't we find this level of beauty in our globalized, cosmopolitan lives, in the vast art of our time? Where can we find beauty untainted by polemical

outcry, economic structure, technological mediation, or social stratification? Something that is beautiful in its craftsmanship, subtleties, and its ability to inspire the deepest and most radiant feelings?

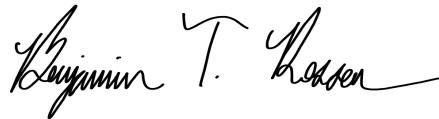
Mulvium is the manifestation of an endless passion to make the world more beautiful. The mission begins with a revitalization of Western civilization's most beautiful forms: symphonic music, fine art, grand architecture, and lush horticulture. When given the choice between the beautiful and commercial, grotesque, contrarian slop, let's begin with the former. With these Western forms as a starting point, Mulvium's movement will foster beauty across more cultures and styles.

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If there is social cohesion amongst the smallest common denominators, I believe there will exist social cohesion at the broadest echelons of society. And I don't mean connection bound to social status, economic stratification, polemical outcry, and technological mediation. I mean the kind of neighborly love and admiration that comes from shared embodied experiences, collective imagination, and collaborative problem-solving.

Sending all my dearest wishes to you, your friends, and family. Let's talk soon, I want to hear about all the ways you fight for beauty in your life! Perhaps, Mulvium can channel this energy.

Fruitfully yours,

A handwritten signature in black ink, reading "Benjamin T. Rossen". The signature is fluid and cursive, with the first name "Benjamin" being the most prominent.

Benjamin T. Rossen
Founder, Mulvium Foundation